

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an article taken from the letters page of a local newspaper:

A recent survey has shown that subjects like Science, Technology, Engineering and Maths – STEM for short – continue not to attract as many females as males. Hong Kong parents, for example, often discourage their daughters from pursuing STEM subjects. In Hong Kong universities, men still dominate these subjects. At the Hong Kong University of Science and Technology women make up just 21% of engineering students. A 2013 survey of 57 companies in Hong Kong showed that women represent fewer than 10% of IT staff at more than half the companies. In the US by 2020 there will be 1.4 million jobs in computing fields, but women are likely to fill only 3% of those jobs.



Girls who show an early interest in STEM subjects often lose interest due to the male-dominated learning environment. A study from Britain shows that girls studying in single-sex schools are nearly 2½ times more likely to study physics at A-level than if they had studied in mixed schools.

We should be showing young women that they can love science and maths. Without enough women in science and technology, we will not have the thinking skills and creative diversity for Hong Kong to compete globally.

Your group is meeting to discuss the number of girls and boys taking STEM subjects in Hong Kong in preparation for a meeting with parents and teachers. You may want to talk about:

- the reasons why fewer girls than boys are attracted to STEM subjects and STEM careers
- what schools and universities can do to encourage more girls to study STEM subjects
- how to persuade parents to let their daughters do STEM subjects
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like Maths?
2. Do you think science subjects are fun?
3. Do you think there are school subjects that girls like more than boys?
4. Did your parents encourage you to choose certain subjects at school?
5. Would you like to work in the technology industry?
6. Do you think boys and girls should go to separate schools?
7. Do you think all STEM subjects should be compulsory at school?
8. Do you think IT should be a compulsory subject for all forms?